



The Bhopal Film Festival - Submission Guidelines

INTRODUCTION & FESTIVAL OVERVIEW

The Bhopal Film Festival (TBFF) is a new independent short film competition taking place on 21 February 2026 at Ravindra Bhawan Auditorium, Bhopal. The festival celebrates the unique culture of Central India and provides a platform for emerging filmmakers to share local stories with pride and reach a wider audience.

Key Details -

No Entry Fee: Participation is free for this first edition to encourage maximum entries.

Event Format: A one-day event featuring selected short films across four categories, followed by the award ceremony. All styles and genres are welcome — what matters most is originality and storytelling.

CATEGORIES OF ENTRY

You can submit your short film in one of the following four categories, based on theme and duration:

- **Fiction (Under 10 Minutes):** Narrative live-action or animated short films up to 10 minutes long (including credits). Any genre or topic is welcome, as long as it's a work of fiction.
- **Non-Fiction (Under 10 Minutes):** Documentary or factual short films up to 10 minutes. This includes documentaries, observational films, or any non-fiction storytelling.
- **Women's Voices (Under 5 Minutes):** Short films (up to 5 minutes) made by women filmmakers that focus on women's stories, issues, or viewpoints. These can be fiction or non-fiction.
- **Heart of India (Under 5 Minutes):** Short films (up to 5 minutes) that show the culture, heritage, people, or stories of Madhya Pradesh (the Heart of India). These can also be fiction or non-fiction.

Note: The duration includes all opening and closing credits. For example, a "5-minute film" must be 5:00 or less in total.

Each film can only be submitted in one category, but you may submit multiple films separately if you wish.

ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA FOR FILMS & FILMMAKERS

To be eligible, please follow these requirements:

- **Short Film Duration:** Films must follow the time limits of their category (either 10 minutes or 5 minutes). There's no minimum length, but even very short films should fit meaningfully within a category.
- **Completion Date:** Films must have been produced after January 1, 2024. Only finished films are accepted; works in progress are not eligible.
Production: The festival focuses on independent cinema. Your film should be made independently, not as a commercial studio production. Sponsors or grants are fine, but the creative control must remain with the filmmaker.
- **Originality:** Films must be your own creative work with original storytelling. Do not use copyrighted material (music, clips, etc.) without permission.
- **Language & Subtitles:** Films in any language are accepted. If your film isn't in English, please include English subtitles. Even if it's in Hindi or a regional language, English subtitles are strongly encouraged for wider understanding. Subtitles are your responsibility to prepare.
- **Geographical Focus:** The festival is open to everyone, but we especially encourage entries from filmmakers from Madhya Pradesh or films connected to Madhya Pradesh/Central India — whether through story, setting, or production. This includes films based in or shot in Madhya Pradesh or made by filmmakers from the state. Highlighting your MP connection can strengthen your submission.
- **Prior Screenings:** Films don't need to be premieres. You can submit films that have screened elsewhere or are online. However, showing something new or lesser known to local audiences adds excitement. If your film has won awards or been shown before, mention it in the form — it won't affect your eligibility.
- **Format & Technical Requirements:** Films shot on any device (camera, DSLR, or phone) are accepted. Submit your film as a digital file or link. It must be in HD quality (720p or 1080p) and in a common format like MP4 or MOV (H.264). If selected, we may ask for a higher-quality version for screening.
- **Age Limit:** Filmmakers aged 16 to 35 years can submit entries.
Submission Limit: There's no limit on how many films you can submit, but each film must have its own entry form and fit only one category.
- **Submission Fee:** No fee will be charged. The festival is free to enter but beware of fake messages or websites asking for money. Only follow the official submission process.

SUBMISSION PROCESS & REQUIREMENTS



Follow these steps to submit your film online:

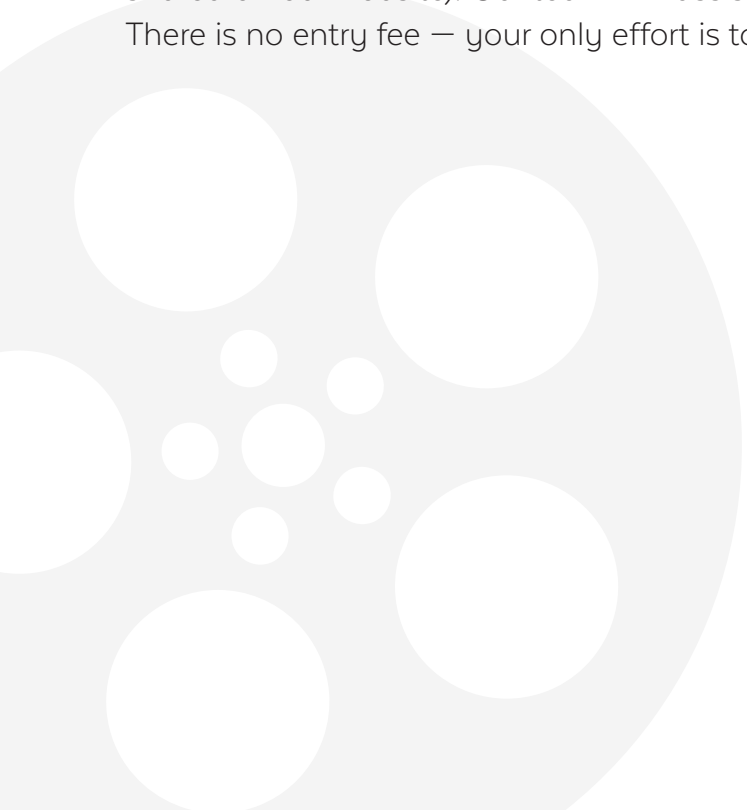
1. Fill Out the Entry Form: Complete the official Bhopal Film Festival Submission Form (Google Form). The link will be available on our website and social media pages. Fill in all required details about you and your film. Incomplete forms won't be accepted.

2. Provide a Screening Link: Share a URL link to your film for viewing. Physical copies like DVDs or drives are not accepted. You can share a Vimeo (preferred), YouTube unlisted, or Google Drive/Dropbox link. Make sure the link can be viewed or downloaded without login requests. If it's password-protected (e.g. on Vimeo), include the password in the form. Keep the Link Active: Your film link must stay active until February 2026. Avoid using links that expire (like WeTransfer). We recommend Google Drive or Vimeo. The file should be under 2GB for 10-minute films and under 1GB for 5-minute films for easier viewing. Your link will only be used by the jury. If your film is selected, we may ask for a better-quality version and permission to use short clips for festival promotion.

3. Submit Before the Deadline: The last date for submission is December 31, 2025 (11:59 PM IST). Late or incomplete entries may not be accepted. Once you submit, you'll receive a confirmation message or email. Contact the festival team before the deadline if you face any issues.

3. Avoid Duplicate Submissions: Submit each film only once. If you have more than one film, fill out a separate form for each.

4. Queries and Support: For help or questions, contact us at the official festival email (to be shared on our website). Our team will assist you with submission or technical issues. There is no entry fee — your only effort is to make a great film and submit it correctly.



SELECTION PROCESS & JURY DELIBERATION

- **Jury Panel:** A panel of respected filmmakers and artists from Madhya Pradesh will review all entries. Their names will be announced on our website once confirmed.
- **Selection Criteria:** Films will be judged on originality, creativity, technical quality, storytelling, and how well they fit their category and the festival's vision.
- **Limited Screenings:** As this is a one-day event, only a limited number of films can be screened. A shortlist of finalists will be chosen in each category.
- **Notification of Selection:** Official selections will be announced by January 30, 2026, about two weeks before the event. Filmmakers will be informed via email or phone, and the list will be posted online.
- **Materials from Selected Films:** Selected filmmakers must confirm participation quickly and share a few materials: high-resolution stills, a poster, a short director bio, a synopsis, and credits. You may also be asked to send a higher-quality film file. Delays could result in replacement by another film.
- **No Changes or Withdrawal:** Once you confirm participation, you cannot withdraw your film. Please submit only if you are ready to screen your film.
- **Screenings:** Selected films will be shown at Ravindra Bhawan before a live audience. A screening schedule will be shared in advance. Filmmakers are encouraged (but not required) to attend, as it's a great opportunity to interact and network.
- **Jury Decision & Awards:** The jury will decide the winners after watching all selected films. Their decisions are final and cannot be challenged.
- **Feedback:** Due to time limits, the festival cannot give individual feedback. If your film isn't selected, it doesn't mean it wasn't good — sometimes it's about fitting the schedule or theme. Keep creating and try again in future editions.

